

A BETTER GAME

2018

Rockstar co-founder and vice president Dan Houser bragged that staff were pulling 100-hour weeks to get the much-anticipated “**Red Dead Redemption 2**” ready for its launch later that October.



The backlash on social media was
swift and immediate.



Timetastic

CRUNCH

Employees are “Early-Career Workers”

Video game development is, in large part, filled with young creatives.

Many come into the industry with a love of games and an idealized view of the process.

Some studios take advantage of the
“naivety” of the early-career workers.
With promises of valuable experience and
future opportunities, game developers
find themselves working unpaid overtime
in poor conditions.

Crunch-as-cred

“When I started in the early ‘80s, it was very much a boys’ club,” he says. “I worked at the publisher US Gold, and I would spend two or three days with a developer making sure that the game would be finished, making cups of tea.”

“There was this false sense of camaraderie, a sense of working really hard and getting it done. Of course, when programmers get tired, they make mistakes, which ends up being very expensive. It was utterly counterproductive.”

- *Charles Cecil (Revolution Studio)*





Poor Time Management

Another major reason behind game development crunch time is a lack of managerial oversight over the development timetable. To avoid this, timelines with clear goals needs to be set up. There should always be leeway if the development timeline has to be shifted due to unforeseen issues.

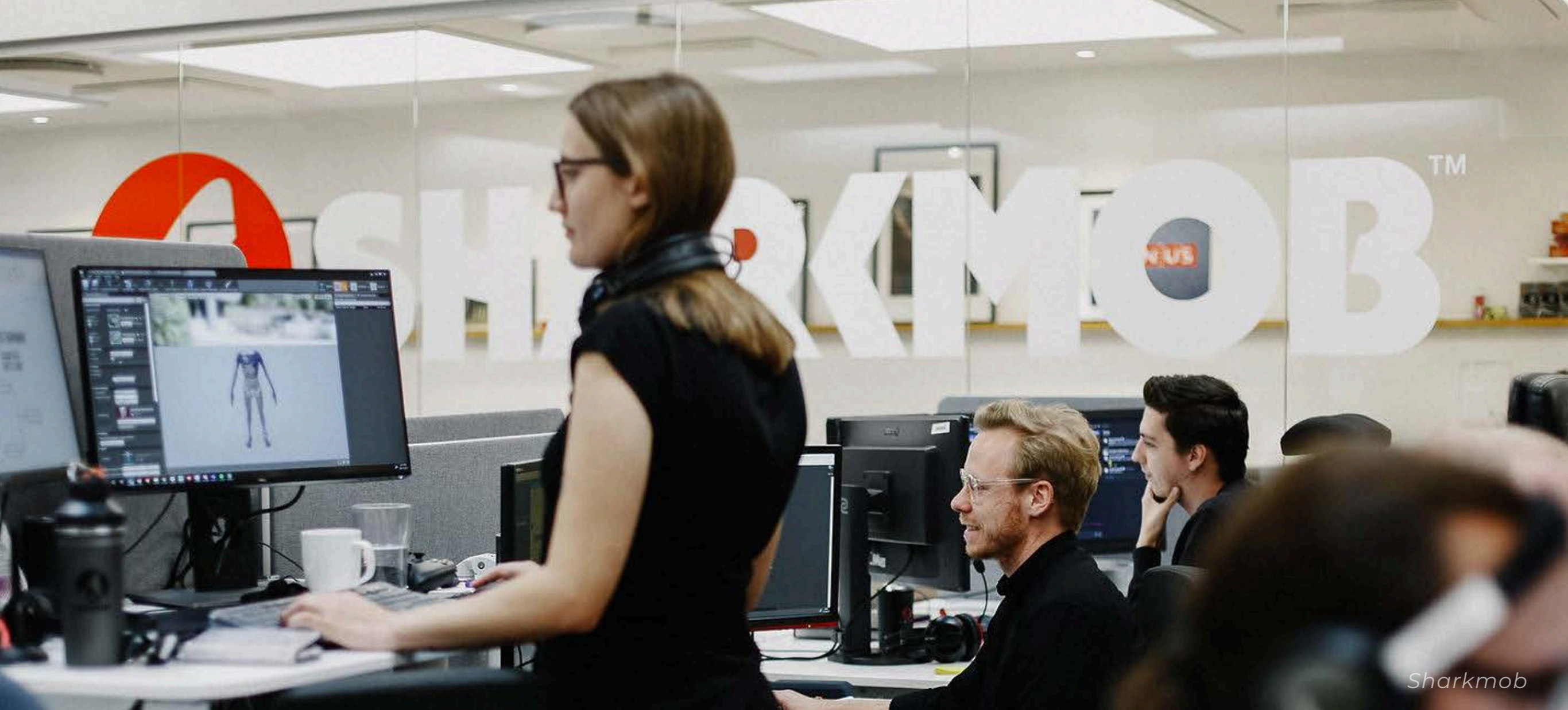
Overpromising during early game promotion

In certain cases, initial plans for a game don't pan out. There are various potential reasons

- features can become too difficult to implement, may not suit the game's overall design, or can make a game impossible to optimize for target platforms.

However, if you've already announced certain features during the initial marketing of your game, your target audience will hold you on to your word.

Gaming culture can be toxic, so even if your game is up to par but lacks the elements you've promised, you may get criticized by the community.



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PRODUCER

What does a producer do?

A video game producer is the project lead responsible for coordinating the employees and schedules to ensure deadlines are met.



“I don't know maths, and I don't know how to draw but I have a lot of ideas and great story lines ideas and I'm just 15.

I pray God will help me.”

- Vicky's thoughts

A video game **producer** will manage employees creating games, playing an executive role during each development phase, and ensuring the quality and timeliness of the teams working on the project.

The role is be typically more business focused than creative. They often manage the budget, as well as ensuring production runs on schedule. They may also be involved in product marketing and advertising campaigns.

The best producers have a
level of creativity and innovation.
As well as a **passion** for gaming
& learning, and the ability
to communicate **creative** ideas
to team members.



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SCOPE

Managing the Scope

Identify what you can do, how much time it will take, what a finished game looks like, and how to plan. **Scope-management** is one of the most important things to consider as a game developer.

How much work can you do?

Typically, this is really just a factor of how much time you have, multiplied by how much skill you have.

- How many consecutive, uninterrupted hours do you have?
- How long does it take you to get **“into the zone”**?
- How long does it take you to implement a new feature/content?
- How organised are you?



How much time will it take?

Think about a game as a set of features.

- Decide what the game is, what are those core features (does your game have levels etc.)?
- Decide what systems, architecture and assets you're going to need.
- Break the features into small, manageable pieces. You should already be thinking of things in terms of classes and systems.

**Divide your game into elements,
and your elements into needs**

In the book *“The Art of Game Design”*
by Jesse Schell, they break a game
down into four categories: **Mechanics,**
Story, Aesthetics and Technology.

EXAMPLE:

MECHANICS

TETRIS



- A mechanic where the player can adjust the speed and rotation of the currently dropping Tetris-tile.
- A mechanic where the tiles destroy themselves and give the player points in case of a matching line of tile types.
- A mechanic where there is always one tile falling on the screen.

OCCARINA OF TIME



- A character controller that acts differently based on game state, equipped inventory & player input.



So in relation to each other, **Tetris** has
low mechanical needs and **Zelda** has
high mechanical needs.